

THE MOUNTAIN ROAD

The King's Crusade — Module Two, Mountain Road Variant

OVERVIEW

Run this module if the party chose the mountain road at the end of Module One. If they chose the sea road, use Module 2A instead — the two are mutually exclusive, and only one is ever played at a given table. The coalition marches overland, through passes and through realms that hold nominal allegiance to the crusade and practically resent every column that crosses their land. This is the road that historically killed an emperor's army; nothing here is that scale, but the module is built from the same material — attrition, weather, and a welcome that is thinner on the ground than the coalition's letters of passage promised. Core scenes run three and a half to four hours; Optional Content fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut cleanly if the table is short on time.

THE SHAPE OF AN OVERLAND WAR

Play the march as a slow accumulation of small costs rather than one large danger. Nobody the party meets on this road is Vale's, or has ever heard of him. A local baron who charges an illegal toll, a mountain crossing that kills through carelessness rather than malice, and a column that is measurably thinner at the far end than it was at the start — that is the whole threat, and it should feel like exactly that: nothing dramatic happening, and the column arriving worn down anyway. Save the wonder and the true danger for Elduvaine; this road's job is to make the party, and the table, feel the distance they have actually crossed to get there.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Long Column	20–30 min	Establishes the grind of the march before anything goes wrong.
2. The Ashgate Ford	30–45 min	A hazard scene, not a fight. See Tiered Skill DCs below.
3. Baron Vell's Toll	90–120 min	Negotiation, and combat if it comes to that. DC table and stat blocks below.
4. The Cost of the Road	30–45 min	What the march has spent, and the road onward — Branch Ledger entry.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Nothing on this road is Vale's doing. Baron Oskar Vell holds a toll-keep at the mouth of the Ashgate pass under a technicality of allegiance to Oksitan that nobody in Oksitan's own court would recognize as binding, and has been quietly taxing every column through his valley for longer than the

coalition's maps have been current. The Ashgate Ford is not cursed or watched; it is simply a fast, cold, early-season river that has killed careless travellers for as long as there has been a road beside it. The column's losses this module — to weather, to the ford, to Vell's harassment if it comes to a fight — are the ordinary cost of moving an army overland, and should be played as exactly that: unglamorous, and real.

DM Only: the Ashgate Ford in Scene 2 is deliberately written to echo the second king's death, which the party will learn about in Module 5 as news from the road they did not take. Do not explain this echo at the table. If a player nearly loses a companion to the water here and later hears that a king died the same way on the other road, let them draw that line themselves — it lands harder unexplained.

SCENE 1: THE LONG COLUMN

However the party spends their days on the march — scouting ahead, riding with the Harrowmark levies, keeping their own company — give the table a real sense of the grind before anything happens: cold breakfasts eaten walking, a supply wagon's wheel that takes half a morning to fix, boots that were dry once and no longer remember it.

The column does not so much travel as accumulate distance. Yesterday looked like today, which will look like tomorrow — until the quartermasters start arguing in low voices about a toll-keep ahead that was not on anyone's map three years ago, and the column's pace, without anyone giving an order, gets a little more careful.

Play this scene short and let it do exactly one job: establish that the march has already cost something before the party reaches either the ford or the baron. A DM who wants more texture here can pull from Optional Content below rather than slowing this scene down.

SCENE 2: THE ASHGATE FORD

The road drops into a valley and the column's scouts report the obvious problem: the ford that should be a shin-deep crossing is running high and fast with early snowmelt, and the column's wagons and the coalition's heavier troops cannot simply walk it.

The water is the color of old iron and moves like something with a purpose. A supply wagon's ox baulks at the bank and has to be led in blindfolded; halfway across, the current takes the wagon sideways for one long, silent moment before the ropes hold and it lurches up onto the far bank, half its load gone downstream.

This is a hazard scene, not a fight. Let the party help however they choose — anchoring ropes, calming panicked animals, physically steadying wagons and people through the crossing — and use the Tiered Skill DCs below to resolve it. Nobody needs to die here for the scene to matter; a lost wagon, a soaked and furious quartermaster, or a near-miss that everyone in earshot will still be talking about that evening is enough. If a PC fails badly and the table wants real stakes, a companion NPC or a nameless soldier can be swept downstream and require a rescue (see DC table) rather than

simply be lost — reserve an actual death here for a table that has clearly bought into the danger and wants it to be real.

THE FORD: TIERED SKILL DCs

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Read the ford and find the safest line across	Survival / Nature	13	Moderate
Steady a wagon or animal mid-crossing	Athletics / Animal Handling	13	Moderate
Anchor a rope line the column can cross on	Athletics	10	Easy
Rescue someone the current has taken	Athletics (Strength save DC 13 for the one swept)	16	Hard

SCENE 3: BARON VELL’S TOLL

A day beyond the ford, the valley narrows to a single defensible road beneath a toll-keep flying a banner that claims allegiance to Oksitan in a way no one in the column entirely believes. Baron Osgar Vell rides out to meet the column himself, backed by mountain scouts who were watching from the ridgeline well before anyone in the column noticed them.

“Oksitan’s allies pass free,” Vell says, in the tone of a man who has said it many times and means something different by it each time. “Everyone else pays the Ashgate toll. I’d hate for there to be some confusion about which one you are.” His scouts, unhurried, have already found the high ground on both sides of the road.

Vell’s scouts are a mixed company of humans, dwarves and one very bored half-orc, all of them local, all of them paid, and none of them under any illusion about what they are guarding. If the party gets one of them talking, the honest complaint is not about the coalition at all — it is about the kobolds in the old workings above the pass, who have been stealing tools for a year and whom nobody has been paid enough to deal with.

RUNNING THE SCENE

Vell will negotiate, and a table that wants to avoid a fight in this narrow, badly-chosen ground should be able to. A successful Charisma (Persuasion) check against DC 16, or convincing proof of a coalition writ of passage the party can produce or talk their way into being believed to have, gets the column through for a token payment. A successful Wisdom (Insight) check against DC 13 reveals that Vell is bluffing about his numbers — he has enough scouts to make a fight costly, not enough to actually hold the pass against a coalition column, and he knows it.

If the party wants to avoid Vell entirely rather than pay or fight him, a DC 16 Survival check (working from a scout’s report or the party’s own reconnaissance) finds a longer goat-track around the toll-keep that costs the column an extra half-day but avoids the confrontation altogether — a different flavor of nonviolent resolution than talking Vell down, and one some tables will prefer.

If it comes to violence — Vell refuses reasonable terms, the party attacks, or negotiations simply fail — his scouts fight from cover on the high ground rather than committing to

open melee, and break off and flee once Vell himself is dropped, captured, or clearly beaten; they are paid skirmishers, not zealots, and have no reason to die for a toll-keep. This should read as a real skirmish in bad terrain, not a formality; see Scaling the Fight for why it is not meant to be this module’s hardest moment regardless.

SCALING THE FIGHT

Baron Vell is the SRD Bandit Captain (CR 2, 450 XP) renamed and reflavored; his scouts are the SRD Scout (CR 1/2, 100 XP each), both taken from the SRD unaltered. Run with Vell plus three Scouts — four total monsters, inside the 3–6 monster band, so no table’s party size crosses a multiplier boundary on its own.

PCs	Base XP	Mult.	Adj. XP	Medium	Reads as
4	750	×2	1,500	2,000	Easy–Medium
5	750	×2	1,500	2,500	Easy–Medium, softer
6	750	×1.5	1,125	3,000	below Easy

As with the wyvern in Module One and Thane in Module 2A, this is not meant to be a Hard or Deadly encounter, and the six-player row is not a problem to fix by adding a fourth Scout — crossing from 4 to 5 monsters is safe, but a table that keeps adding bodies for a larger party risks crossing into the 7–10 monster band, which jumps the multiplier up a full step and can overcorrect badly. If a table of six wants more bite, the terrain itself is the honest lever: Vell’s scouts firing from height and cover, forcing difficult ground or cover checks to close the distance, does more to raise the real difficulty than another body would.

STAT BLOCKS

Baron Osgar Vell

Medium humanoid (human), any non-lawful alignment — SRD Bandit Captain, renamed

Armor Class: 15 (studded leather armor)

Hit Points: 65 (10d8 + 20)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws: Str +4, Dex +5, Wis +2

Skills: Athletics +4, Deception +4

Senses: passive Perception 10

Languages: Common

Challenge: 2 (450 XP)

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Vell makes three melee attacks: two with his scimitar and one with his dagger. Or he makes two ranged attacks with his daggers.

Scimitar. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d6 + 3) slashing damage.

Dagger. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage.

REACTIONS

Parry. Vell adds 2 to his AC against one melee attack that would hit him. To do so, he must see the attacker and be wielding a melee weapon.

Ashgate Scout

Medium humanoid (any race), any alignment — SRD Scout, unmodified

Armor Class: 13 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 16 (3d8 + 3)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

Skills: Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5

Senses: passive Perception 15

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP)

Keen Hearing and Sight. The scout has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or sight.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The scout makes two melee attacks or two ranged attacks.

Shortsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Longbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, range 150/600 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing damage.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Talk Vell down to a token toll	Persuasion	16	Hard
Read that Vell's numbers are a bluff	Insight	13	Moderate
Find a way around the toll-keep entirely	Survival	16	Hard
Spot the scouts on the ridgeline before they act	Perception	16	Hard (their passive Perception is 15)

SCENE 4: THE COST OF THE ROAD

However the ford and the toll-keep were settled, the column presses on beyond Ashgate with a tally the quartermasters keep quietly rather than announce: a wagon lost or delayed, a handful of soldiers hurt or worse, and whatever the crossing with Vell cost in time, coin, or blood. None of it threatens the crusade. All of it is real.

Garrick Hollow, the column's hired guide, falls into step beside the party as the toll-keep drops out of sight behind them. "Every mile past here I know less than the mile before it," he says, without much apparent concern. "Which is either a comfort or it isn't, depending on how you've found my company so far."

This is where the module ends, and where the DM should let the weight of the road actually register — a brief moment of the column taking stock, tending its wounded, and continuing, rather than a triumphant scene. Hand off directly to Module 3, Landfall, and the first sight of Elduvaine. The road not taken catches up with the party later, in Module 5, when what happened to Raimon V of Oksitan at a Vaskren ford reaches them as news.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

The Back of the Charter expands the toll negotiation and adds ten minutes. The Cold Stair is how the march is run. The Signposted Corridor belongs to the Old Workings and stays in Optional Content, where it is worth sixty minutes to a table that wants a dungeon.

THE PUZZLE: THE BACK OF THE CHARTER

Baron Vell's toll is legal, and that is the whole difficulty with Baron Vell. The charter is real, it is four generations old, it hangs framed in the keep's hall, and it says what he may charge. He will show it to anybody. He is proud of it.

He has never read the back.

What the front says: the holder of Ashgate keep may levy a toll on the ford, at rates set out in a schedule, per head and per axle, in perpetuity.

What the back says: the charter is granted in exchange for the keep maintaining the ford, the causeway and the winter marks, and for the keep passing free of toll any body of men raised under a summons of the Crown.

Getting to it requires noticing that a document hanging in a frame has a reverse, which is a DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) check or simply a player asking. Getting it out of the frame without Vell's permission is a DC 15 Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check. Getting Vell to take it out himself is a DC 16 Charisma (Persuasion) check and is much the better scene, because he will do it, and he will read it, and the party will watch him work out what it says.

DM Only: Vell is not a fraud and has not been cheating anybody. His great-grandfather knew about the clause; his grandfather did not; the family has collected in good faith for two generations on a document nobody had turned over. When he reads it he goes quiet, and then he honours it, because he is a man whose entire identity is that his charter

is legitimate and he has just found out what legitimate costs. Let the party win this without humiliating him. If they humiliate him anyway, he still honours it, and the column still crosses, and something has been broken that did not need to be.

THE PUZZLE: THE SIGNPOSTED CORRIDOR

The kobolds of the Old Workings have had two generations and nothing else to do. Every junction in the upper gallery is trapped, and every trap is signposted – carefully, legibly, and in Draconic, which they do not consider a trick and which everyone who has died here has considered one.

The signs are honest. That is the puzzle. A party that can read Draconic walks through the entire complex unharmed; a party that cannot must work out that the marks are warnings rather than decoration, and then work out which is which by watching what the kobolds themselves do.

The mark	What it says	What is actually there
Three scratches, descending	Falling	A covered pit, 20 ft. DC 13 Dexterity save or 2d6 damage and prone.
A circle with a line through	Do not stand	Pressure plate. DC 14 Dexterity save or a rock fall for 3d6 bludgeoning in a 10-ft. square.
A wave	Water	The flooded lower gallery. Not a trap. A genuine warning, and the thing they want help with.
Two dots and a stroke	Ours, do not touch	A ladder. It is a ladder. There is nothing else to it and a paranoid party will spend twenty minutes on it.
A hand, open	Come in, talk	The negotiating chamber. They have prepared a speech and are hurt if nobody hears it.

DM Only: the whole encounter tips on whether a party assumes signposting is malice. If they blunder through, they take real damage from traps that told them, in writing, what they were. If they stop and think, they get sixty kobolds who would very much like to be left alone, will pay in silver they have no use for, and want somebody to do something about what is in the flooded lower gallery. Reward the reading. Do not punish the fighting, but do not soften it either.

SET PIECE: THE COLD STAIR IN WEATHER

Eleven miles of switchback cut into the eastern face, wind coming across rather than along, no water for the middle four miles and no shelter for the last three. Run it as an environment that is trying to kill the column, because it is.

“The wind does not gust here. It leans. It has been leaning against your left shoulder for six hours and you have been walking with your body at an angle for so long that when the road turns and it stops, you stagger, and the man behind you laughs, and then it turns again and he stops laughing.”

The hazard. Each of the three days on the Stair, every character makes a DC 12 Constitution saving throw at nightfall. On a failure they gain one level of exhaustion. Characters who reach an intact refuge hut, or who are sheltered by somebody who plans, make the save with advantage; characters who pushed on past the last hut make it with disadvantage.

The problem. Somebody has been stripping the refuge huts for roofing timber. Two of the four are open to the sky. This is a small crime at sea level and a lethal one at five thousand feet, and the party can find out who is doing it in an afternoon: it is the Kir Halloway carters, who are cold, who are also right that nobody has repaired the huts in nine years, and who are entirely prepared to be shouted at.

The set piece. On the second night, a section of the column ahead does not make the hut. Forty people, in the open, in the dark, three quarters of a mile up the road. The party can go back for them. Every hour they spend doing it is an hour they are also in the open, and the DM should track their own exhaustion honestly and out loud.

NPC PROFILES

GARRICK HOLLOW

A half-elf hired out of the last town before the passes, paid to know these mountains better than the coalition’s own maps do, which he does. Speech: unbothered, faintly dry, prone to stating bad news as though it were simply weather. Genuinely good at his job, and genuinely indifferent to whether anyone finds that reassuring.

Open thread: Garrick knows this road and, plausibly, others – a DM can bring him back as a recurring guide for any later overland stretch of the campaign, or use him as the source of a rumor or shortcut when the party needs one and has no other way to justify finding it.

BARON OSGAR VELL

Comfortable in bad terrain the way a man is comfortable in a home he built himself. Speech: measured, faintly amused, treats the toll as a fact of nature rather than a crime. Not personally vicious – his scouts are paid, not fanatical, and he has no interest in a fight he does not expect to win.

Open thread: if he survives – paid off, talked down, or simply outmaneuvered – Vell keeps his keep and his technicality of allegiance, and a DM can bring him back later as a minor, recurring complication on any road that passes near Ashgate, or as a source of local intelligence if the party ever needs a favor from someone who owes them one.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

THE OLD WORKINGS

Above the toll-keep, half a day off the road, an abandoned dwarven working has been reoccupied by kobolds — forty or so, organised, and responsible for most of what the valley has lost to theft in the past year. They are not a threat to a coalition column and know it; what they are is a warren of pit traps, tripped rockfalls and very good tunnel discipline in a space too tight for anyone to bring numbers to bear.

Run six to ten kobolds (SRD, CR 1/8, 25 XP each) in terrain that does all their work for them: darkvision against a party carrying light, pack tactics wherever two can reach the same target, and a readiness to collapse a passage and leave rather than lose. The honest resolution here is not slaughter — a party that offers the kobolds the tools instead of taking them back can buy a guide through the workings and out above the toll-keep entirely, which is a third route past Vell that no one in the column has thought of.

If a table wants something heavier on this road instead, an ogre (SRD, CR 2, 450 XP) has been working the same stretch of scree for a season and is a straightforward, honest, dangerous obstacle for a party of this level — the mountain road's equivalent of weather with arms.

KIR HALLOWAY, AND THE WOMAN WHO HAS BEEN COUNTING

Two days above Ashgate, wedged into a valley that gets four hours of direct sun in winter, Kir Holloway is the last place on this road where anybody can buy anything: one inn with eleven beds, four warehouses, a market on the third day of every week regardless of weather or war, and a population of dwarves, humans and a startling number of tieflings whose families came up from Norvatch three generations back and stayed for the trade. After this it is the pass, and then Elduvaine, and Elduvaine has permits.

A Norvatch house factor has kept a permanent office here for sixty years. She is courteous, entirely unhurried, and will discuss anything the party can pay for. What she actually knows, and will sell cheaply because she does not regard it as sensitive, is not what has been going up the road. It is what has been coming down it, out of Elduvaine, for three years: volume, direction, and the fact that it tripled in the second year and has not stopped.

DM Only: this is the mountain road's equivalent of the manifest in Thane's cellar, and it does the same job — one early, undramatic, entirely legal document that will fit against Doria Kell in Module Four and the ledgers in Module Ten. The factor is not a spy and has no agenda. She is a professional in a cold valley who has been writing numbers down for sixty years and is mildly pleased that somebody finally asked to see them.

BARROWFELL

Two days off the road, four hundred barrows across nine miles of moor, raised by people nobody can now name on a schedule nobody can reconstruct. Harrowmark's scholars think they predate the kingdom by a wide margin. Harrowmark's shepherds think they should be left alone and

have been proved right on eleven recorded occasions. A table that wants a dungeon rather than a march can spend an entire session up here.

DM Only: Barrowfell has nothing whatever to do with Vale, Elduvaine, or this war, and that is the entire point of it. A setting where every ruin is plot is a setting with no history in it. Put something genuinely old and genuinely unrelated down here, let the party spend an optional session on it, and never connect it to anything — including, especially, at the end of the campaign when it would be very easy to.

WHAT THE COLUMN TALKS ABOUT

Before Ashgate, let the party spend some idle marching time among the coalition's ordinary soldiers — Harrowmark levies, and the first Oksitan or Auberitz troops the party has walked near long enough to actually talk to. Play this for texture: homesickness, rumors about Elduvaine that are mostly wrong, and the particular, unglamorous humor of people who have been walking together for weeks. No mechanical stakes.

THE WOUNDED WAGON

If the table wants more to do before the ford, a supply wagon has thrown a wheel on bad road and needs help before the column can move again — a short, low-stakes problem-solving scene (Investigation or Athletics, DC 10) that adds texture and a chance for a less combat-oriented character to shine, without adding a beat the module needs.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **What the ford cost.** A wagon, a delay, a near-miss, or an actual loss — track which, and how the party responded. This has no mechanical follow-up but is worth a callback when the drowned king's fate reaches the party in Module 5.
- **How Vell's toll was settled.** Paid, talked down, bypassed, or fought — track which. A bypassed or talked-down Vell keeps his keep and his technicality of allegiance, which a DM can raise again if the coalition's relationship with Oksitan becomes a live question later in the campaign.

LOOT

- **Vell's writ.** A document, genuine as far as it goes, establishing his technicality of allegiance to Oksitan. Not valuable in itself, but a useful thread if a DM wants to raise the coalition's internal reliability as a question later in the campaign.
- **A mountain-forged blade.** Taken from Vell or bought through Garrick's local contacts — a +1 weapon of its type, dwarven work out of the old valley forges, unremarkable to look at and better than anything the party marched in with.
- **Kobold tunnel-charts.** If the old workings were dealt with peaceably — scratched on slate, entirely accurate, and a standing shortcut through the Ashgate range that a DM can honour any time the campaign comes back this way.

- **Salvage from the ford.** Whatever of the lost wagon's cargo the party recovers or the column can spare from what remains — modest, practical supplies rather than treasure, playable as a small easing of the crusade's logistics rather than a coin payout at 5th level.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*